

Transmutation, Not Transmission

Consider the cultures most often described as demonic: masks distorted into terrifying faces, bodies painted in blood and ash, drums that overwhelm thought, dancers entering trance, voices becoming screams, and ceremonies that end in tears, trembling, or collapse. What harm is occurring in the image itself? Often none. What frightens the observer is not violence, but the sight of suffering and energy expressed without apology.

Such expression overwhelms the senses because it threatens the defended self. The ego survives by maintaining boundaries between the civilized and the savage, the sane and the possessed, the beautiful and the grotesque, the divine and the demonic. When another person embodies grief, rage, appetite, death, or ecstasy with sufficient intensity, those boundaries begin to fail. The observer recognizes forces that also exist within themselves, and that recognition feels like annihilation.

Instead of allowing the ego to be broken open, human beings have repeatedly destroyed the person carrying the revelation. What is unfamiliar is called frightening; what is frightening is called dangerous; what is called dangerous becomes permissible to suppress, convert, displace, enslave, or kill. Entire peoples have been punished not only for what they did, but for what their bodies, rituals, gods, and expressions forced others to feel.

This does not explain every conquest or every system of slavery. Greed, land, power, and material interest remain real. But it is astonishing that fear of another people's appearance, suffering, spiritual intensity, or unrestrained expression could become even one part of the machinery through which millions were displaced and destroyed. "It frightened us" has too often been treated as sufficient evidence that something should not exist.

Yet the force being feared is not inherently evil. It is suffering that has not yet found alignment. It is energy seeking a form through which it can become intelligible and useful. When resisted, it appears monstrous because it collides continuously with the structures attempting to contain or deny it. When transmitted unchanged, it becomes violence, domination, resentment, and inherited trauma. But when accepted, and directed toward a purpose, the same force becomes music, dance, protection, labour, devotion, architecture, art, and love.

This is transmutation rather than transmission.

Transmission sends the wound onward. The wounded person finds another body, generation, class, race, or nation into which the pain can be deposited. Transmutation takes the pain and refuses to let it leave in the form in which it came. It converts grief into beauty, rage into courage, terror into vigilance, appetite into creation, and darkness into the energy for life.

Alignment is the condition that makes this conversion possible. Alignment does not mean making darkness behave like light or forcing the Rakshasa to imitate the Deva. It means placing every force within the order appropriate to it. Energy receives direction. Structure receives life. Ahamkaram supplies a self capable of acting, while Maryada prevents that self from consuming everything it encounters.

Once aligned, darkness stops appearing dark. It no longer meets resistance, and therefore no longer produces the violent outline through which it had been perceived. It becomes immeasurable, illegible, and overwhelming—like the blinding white light described in spiritual texts, a radiance so complete that distinction itself disappears.

The same must be true of light. Light without alignment becomes sterile, blinding, judgmental, and tyrannical. The Deva, the engineer, and the civilizing force are not liberated merely because they identify themselves with order. They too must surrender their attachment to superiority, control, purity, and form. Light must accept darkness as its energy, just as darkness must accept light as its direction.

Neither white nor dark is liberated through victory over the other. Each is liberated only through alignment with the laws that make both necessary.

The deepest cosmic distinction is therefore not between light and darkness, Deva and Rakshasa, white and black, master and slave. It is between force that transmits its conflict and force that transmutes it. One reproduces the wound. The other receives the wound, carries its full energy, and returns it to the world as purpose and art.

Liberation exists not in conflict, but rather in prayer to that which is above conflict, there is no exclusivity to that, there is no need to engage another for that, and there is no need to argue or debate that. To live well is to be aligned, and to be aligned is to profit from the lower cost structure you've earned through the intense penance of transmutation and absolved faith.